A Short Guide to Writing Exegetical Papers

(This only applies to Biblical exegetical papers, not other essays in other courses.)

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1. Title Page

Imitate the title page below.

"Be Strong in the Lord"

An Exegetical Paper on
Ephesians 6:10-16

by

Your Name
Your Student ID number

Interpreting the Bible
Name of Institution
J. Scott Duvall
12 March 2012

Put a short statement here that sums up the theme of your text.

Put your passage here, since it's probably not Ephesians 6.

Everyone knows their name, but they sometimes forget to put it on their paper.

Course Name,
Name of Institution
Lecturer's Name
Date of Submission

2. Main Idea and Table of Contents Page (1 Page)

Identify the text that you have been assigned and summarize its main idea in one sentence. Then present a full table of contents of your paper, showing how the main idea unfolds. For each main point of your outline, show the corresponding verses in brackets. All of the verses of your passage should be included in the main points of your outline.

Again, take a look at the example on the following page.

Statement of the main idea

Main points of outline

Summary Statement: Ephesians 3:14-21

Paul prays for the church of Ephesus to comprehend the love of Christ and to experience the fullness of God.

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Subpoints of the outline with Bible verses in parentheses. Use "v." for one verse and "vv." for two or more verses.

In your outline, if you have an "3.1," you must have a "3.2."

Verse 16a refers to the first part of that verse, 16b refers to the second part, 16c to the third part, and so on.

3. Introduction (1/2 page)

Think about writing your Introduction last of all. Once you have written the paper, writing the Introduction is a lot easier. Plus, you will also have all the information you need to write a more effective Introduction if you wait until the end of the process to write it. This does not mean that you can throw something together at the last minute and expect to have a good Introduction.

This one or two-paragraph section needs to do two things. First, you should get your reader's attention. Remember that you are writing a research paper so don't resort to gimmicks. No one will want to read your paper if the Introduction is superficial and cheesy. Think about how the message of your passage connects with the needs of your readers and use this intersection to construct your Introduction. Read over your application section to get an idea of how your passage connects with people today.

Second, you should introduce the main ideas and topics included in your passage. Give your readers a preview of what they can expect to find in the paper. You don't need to go into a great deal of detail, but you do need to alert them in a general way about what they are getting themselves into by reading your paper.

4. Context (1-2 pages)

You might want to review chapters 6-8 in *Grasping God's Word* before you attempt this section. You need to do two things in this section of your paper. You begin this part of your paper by describing the historical-cultural situation of both the biblical writer (e.g., Paul, James, Peter) and the biblical audience (e.g., the recipients of Colossians or James or 1 Peter). See *GGW* 118-123.

Where do find this information? Start by reading the introduction to the book in a good study Bible (e.g., *The NIV Study Bible*). Then consult the other resources mentioned in *GGW* 124-128 for more information. Your reader needs to understand the situation of the author and the audience before the content of your passage will make sense.

When referring to whole chapters of a book of the Bible, you should spell it out with no abbreviations.

The second thing you need to include in this Context section is a paragraph or two about the surrounding context of your passage (see *GGW*, 152-153). Here you will describe the flow of thought in the book (or a larger section like Romans 5-8) and discuss how your passage fits into that flow of thought. Look closely at how your passage relates to what comes before it and what follows it (see *GGW*, 156-161 for how to identify the surrounding context). Check out the example below from Douglas Moo (*NIV Application Commentary: Romans*) for Romans 8:26-27:

You should also look in commentaries at the place where they begin to discuss your passage. They will often introduce the discussion by setting up the surrounding context.

> *"In the same way, the Spirit helps us in our weakness. We do not know what we ought to pray for, but the Spirit himself intercedes for us with groans that words cannot express. And he who searches our hearts knows the mind of the Spirit, because the Spirit intercedes for the saints in accordance with God's will."*

> "Paul began the great second section of his exposition of the gospel [Romans 5-8] by assuring believers of their sure hope for salvation in the judgment (5:1-11). [In Rom. 8;18-30] he now returns to where he started, setting before us the wonderful fact and the solid basis for our hope as Christians. The immediate stimulus is the end of 8:17, where he reminded us that we need to share in Christ's sufferings if we expect to share in his glory. The theme of 8:18-30 is the believer's future glory. This passage begins ('the glory that will be revealed in us,' v. 18) and ends ('those he justified, he also glorified,' v. 30) on this note.
>
> In between, Paul makes two basic points about this glory. First, it is the climax in God's plan both for his people and for his creation generally. Since we have not reached that climax, we must eagerly and patiently wait for it (vv. 18-25). Second, God himself provides what we need in order to wait eagerly and patiently. The Spirit helps us pray (vv. 26-27), and God promises to oversee everything for our good (v. 28) according to his unbreakable plan for us (vv. 29-30)." (Moo, 2005:265-266).

When the reader finishes reading Moo's two paragraphs in the box, he or she will have a good idea of how 8:26-27 fits into Paul's thought flow in the letter. You could go into a bit more detail explaining the specific role of 8:26-27, but this gives you an idea of how to get started.

5. Content Section (5-8 pages)

This section is the body of your paper and the heart of your exegetical work. First, let's talk about how this section should look in your paper. Then, I'll suggest one helpful way of pulling together all the information that needs to be included. Before moving on to the Application section, I'll give you a short list of things to avoid.

In terms of how the Content section should look, use the main headings of your outline along with the verse(s) of the text to organize this section. Double space the explanation that follows each heading. Use 25mm margins and a twelve-point font. Add page numbers to the lower right-hand corner of each page. When you are quoting an author, or giving credit for an idea or showing who holds a certain position in a debate, you need to cite your source. For this paper you can cite your sources by adding their name and the page number(s) in the book you are consulting after the quote, idea, or position. The sample page below illustrates these matters of form.

Put the main point of the outline in bold and the verses in parentheses.

Put the verse(s) in italics and indent them.

1. Paul reverently offers his prayer to the Father (3:14-15).

For this reason I kneel before the Father, from whom his whole family in heaven and on earth derives its name.

As you explain the meaning of this section, use double spacing like I'm doing now. When you come to a new section, just skip a line and start with your next main point in the outline and the accompanying verse(s).

Skip a line between sections.

Double-space the body of your paper. The explanation in a real paper would be much longer than my example.

2. Paul prays for the believers in Ephesus to know Christ (3:16-17a).

I pray that out of his glorious riches he may strengthen you with power through his Spirit in your inner being, so that Christ may dwell in your hearts through faith.

Here you start explaining the next section. At the end of this sentence you will see an example of how to cite your sources (Nystrom, 1997:92). Explanation, explanation, even more explanation, much more explanation, additional explanation goes here, …

Cite sources by putting the author's last name and page number(s) in brackets. The full bibliography for each source you cite should be included in your reference list.

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Page numbers go in the lower right-hand corner.

What kind of information do you need to include in the Content section? The main thing you are after is the meaning of the text. As you have seen from what we have learned this semester, the meaning of the text includes the meaning of words, phrases, sentences, and paragraphs, as well as the meaning of elements in that text that need to be illumined by looking at the historical-cultural context (see GGW, 121-123, 128-135). The meaning of the text also involves understanding how all the smaller pieces fit together along with identifying the theological principles communicated by the text (review *GGW*, 261-262).

HINT: You should definitely read this very important paragraph.

How do you find and pull together all this information? I would suggest the following:

1. Do the observation work on your passage (remember chapters 3-5 of *GGW*?).
2. Do your word studies.
3. Consult outside sources, especially good commentaries on your passage.
4. Identify the theological principles communicated by your passage.
5. Organize your information, one section at a time. You might find it helpful to make a rough outline of how you plan to explain the meaning of this section:
    - opening sentence
    - explain the conjunction "therefore" (what does it point back to)
    - explain the command (put word study info here)
    - explain the "armour of God" from background info
    - explain the result statement "so that …"
    - …
6. Actually write your explanation. Then rewrite it for an even better paper.

As you write your Content section, there are some things you want to AVOID:

- Don't try to include everything that you have learned in the process of interpretation.
- Don't preach to the reader. You are writing an exegetical paper, not a sermon.
- Don't substitute a fluffy illustration or touching testimony for solid biblical interpretation.
- Don't lose sight of your goal of explaining the meaning of the text. Stay focused on this goal and don't get lost in all the details.
- Don't quote large sections of text from a secondary source and expect to impress your professor.
- Don't put off writing this paper until the last minute.
- When an issue is debated by interpreters, don't ignore the debate. Briefly explain the main options, make your choice and give your reasons.

7. Application Section (1 page)

Consider reviewing GGW, chapter 13 before writing this section. This part of your paper should include three specific parts (see GGW, 239-246):

1. Begin with a paragraph where you observe how the principles in your passage address the original situation. You are looking for the intersection between the problem/question (original situation) and the solution/answer (theological principles from the passage). Find this intersection by identifying the key elements within the passage.

2. Continue your Application page by writing about a situation in our day that parallels the original situation. You are looking for a situation that contains all the key elements that you identified in the first part of your application page (see *GGW*, 239 for an example). This is the place that many interpreters veer off course. Make sure your parallel situation is a general parallel by asking whether your situation contains all the key elements.

3. Wrap-up your Application page by making your application(s) specific. Creating a real-world scenario is a very good way to make your application specific.

8. Reference List (1 page)

Add a formal reference list of the sources you cite in your paper. See the example below as well as the extended bibliography of resources in GGW, 459-491.

Single space each entry with a double space between them.

REFERENCE LIST

Johnson, L.T. 1995. The letter of James. Anchor Bible Yale commentary. New York: Doubleday.

Moo, D.J. 2000. The letter of James. Pillar New Testament commentary. Grand Rapids: Eerdmans.

Motyer, J.A. 1985. The message of James: the test of faith. The Bible speaks today. Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity.

Nystrom, D.P. 1997. James. The NIV application commentary. Grand Rapids: Zondervan.

Checklist

- ☐ I have double-spaced the paper with a twelve-point font and 25mm margins.
- ☐ The paper has a title page that includes the required information.
- ☐ The paper is between nine and thirteen pages long.
- ☐ I have cited sources in accordance with the NWU Harvard style.
- ☐ My main idea summarizes the entire passage in one sentence.
- ☐ All verses in the passage are included in my outline.
- ☐ The main points of my outline serve as subheadings in the body of my paper.
- ☐ My Introduction gains the reader's attention and previews the main ideas of the passage.
- ☐ I discuss both the historical-cultural context and the surrounding context.
- ☐ I explain the meaning of critical words in my passage.
- ☐ I have consulted and cited at least four reputable sources.
- ☐ I discuss several applications of this passage for a contemporary audience according to the approach to application used in *GGW*.
- ☐ I include a bibliography of sources cited in the paper.
- ☐ I have proofread the paper.

Marking

The marking criteria will be different for each professor. Below is one way your paper could be marked:

- Form and style (neatness, typing, spelling, grammar, etc.) - 10%
- Research (use of sources) - 10%
- Main idea and outline - 15%
- Context (historical-cultural, surrounding, elements within passage) - 15%
- Content - 35%
- Application - 15%